

## Charles Ausi

### Sample Project: Enterprise Data & Analytics Platform Modernization

**Type:** Program Case Study — Fictional / Illustrative **Domain:** Data Platform · Financial Services · Analytics Engineering **Program Scale:** \$3.1M CAD · 18 Months · Cross-functional team of 22

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#### Program Snapshot

| Field             | Detail                                                          |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Program Name      | Enterprise Data & Analytics Platform Modernization (EDAPM)      |
| Organization Type | Mid-size Canadian financial institution (~\$12B AUM)            |
| Program Manager   | Charles Ausi                                                    |
| Duration          | 18 months                                                       |
| Budget            | \$3,100,000 CAD (delivered at \$3,045,000, 1.8% under)          |
| Team Size         | 22 (internal: 14 / vendor: 8)                                   |
| Outcome           | ✅ Delivered on time · ✅ Under budget · ✅ Full adoption achieved |

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#### The Problem

The organization's reporting and analytics infrastructure had grown organically over 11 years into a fragmented ecosystem of disconnected data silos, manual extract-transform-load (ETL) processes, and inconsistent business intelligence (BI) outputs. Business units were maintaining their own spreadsheet-based reporting, producing conflicting numbers for the same metrics. Regulatory reporting required 3-5 days of manual effort per submission cycle. Leadership lacked a single, trusted source of truth for operational and financial performance data.

#### The business impact was significant:

- Regulatory submissions carried a material risk of error due to manual data assembly
- Finance and Risk teams spent an estimated 40% of their time reconciling data rather than analyzing it
- Time-to-insight for executive decisions averaged 6-8 business days
- Two near-miss audit findings in 18 months had elevated regulatory scrutiny

The organization needed a modern, governed data platform — built once, trusted everywhere.

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## **Program Objectives**

1. Implement a cloud-based enterprise data platform consolidating 11 source systems into a single governed data layer
  2. Automate regulatory reporting pipelines, reducing manual effort by at least 70%
  3. Deliver self-service BI capability to 200+ business users across Finance, Risk, Compliance, and Operations
  4. Establish a data governance framework with documented lineage, ownership, and quality standards
  5. Decommission 3 legacy reporting environments by program close
  6. Achieve all objectives within the approved budget and 18-month timeline
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## **Program Scope**

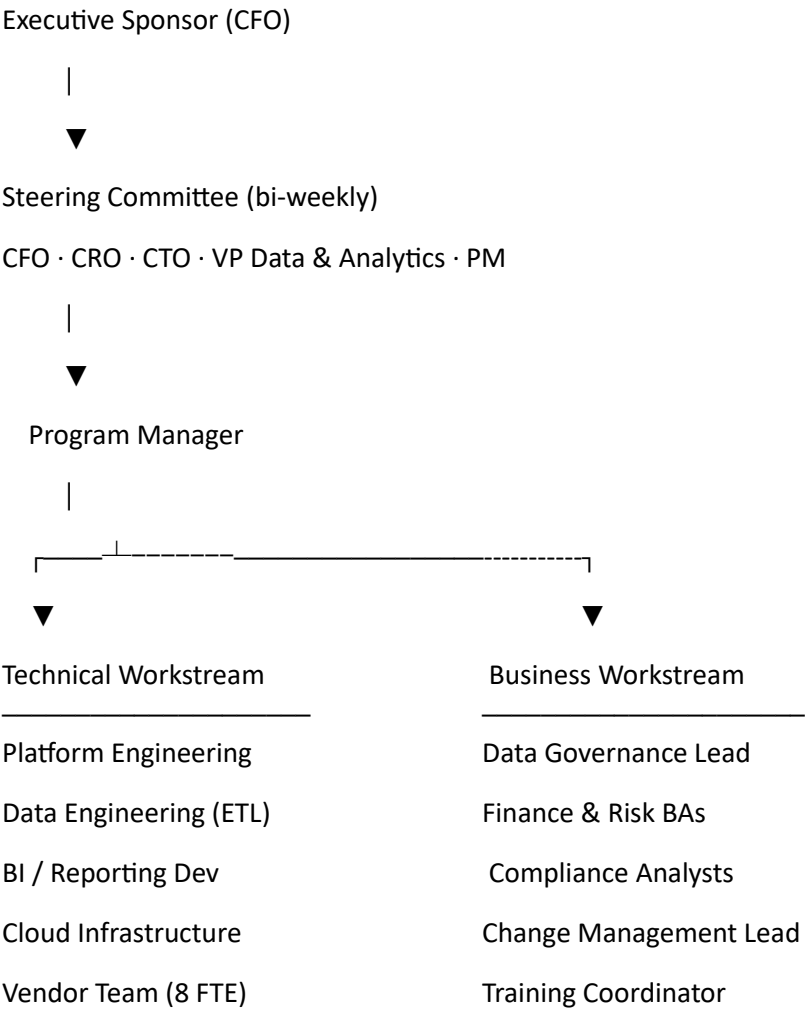
### **In Scope**

- Cloud data warehouse implementation (Azure Synapse Analytics)
- ETL/ELT pipeline development for 11 source systems (core banking, CRM, GL, treasury, AML platform, HR, and 5 ancillary feeds)
- Data governance framework: ownership model, data dictionary, lineage documentation, quality thresholds
- Enterprise BI layer: Power BI semantic model, certified dataset library, executive dashboards
- Regulatory reporting automation: 4 submission types (OSFI, FINTRAC, internal audit, board reporting)
- Change management: training program for 200+ business users, super-user network, adoption measurement
- Legacy system decommissioning: 3 environments (post-parallel run validation)

### **Out of Scope**

- Source system modifications (owned by separate IT workstreams)
  - Real-time streaming data (Phase 2, separate program)
  - International regulatory reporting
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Governance Structure



**Steering Committee cadence:** Bi-weekly · 60 min **Working group cadence:** Weekly per workstream · 45 min **Vendor governance review:** Monthly · 60 min

Delivery Approach

The program was structured using a **hybrid delivery model** - Agile sprints (2-week) for data engineering and BI development, with Waterfall milestone governance for platform infrastructure, vendor contracting, and regulatory submission validation.

## Program Phases

| Phase                                         | Duration     | Key Activities                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Phase 0 - Discovery &amp; Architecture</b> | Months 1-2   | Source system assessment, data catalogue inventory, architecture design, vendor selection               |
| <b>Phase 1 - Platform Foundation</b>          | Months 3-5   | Cloud infrastructure provisioning, data warehouse build, core pipeline development (4 priority sources) |
| <b>Phase 2 - Pipeline Expansion</b>           | Months 6-10  | Remaining 7 source system integrations, data quality framework, governance tooling                      |
| <b>Phase 3 - BI &amp; Reporting Layer</b>     | Months 9-14  | Semantic model built, certified dataset library, executive dashboards, regulatory reporting automation  |
| <b>Phase 4 - UAT &amp; Change Management</b>  | Months 13-16 | Business UAT, super-user training, parallel run with legacy systems, adoption measurement               |
| <b>Phase 5 - Cutover &amp; Hypercare</b>      | Months 17-18 | Production go-live, legacy decommission, hypercare support, program closure                             |

*Phases 3 and 4 overlapped by design to allow iterative business feedback during BI development.*

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## Key Risks Managed

| Risk                                                                             | Severity                                                                                   | How It Was Managed                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Source system data quality issues discovered during profiling (Month 1)          |  High   | Accelerated data profiling exercise in Phase 0; created a data remediation workstream; added a 3-week buffer to the pipeline delivery schedule |
| Vendor resourcing shortfall during Phase 2 peak (Month 7)                        |  High   | Invoked SLA clause; escalated to vendor account executive; supplementary contractor onboarded within 10 days                                   |
| Business stakeholder availability is limited during UAT (holiday period overlap) |  Medium | UAT schedule confirmed and calendar-blocked in Month 10; critical-path test cases prioritized and completed first                              |
| Regulatory requirement changes (FINTRAC reporting format update mid-program)     |  Medium | Compliance Director flagged early via Steering Committee; scope change assessed and absorbed within existing contingency                       |
| Legacy system decommission dependency on parallel run sign-off                   |  Medium | Parallel run started 6 weeks ahead of planned decommission date; formal sign-off checklist established                                         |

**Contingency drawn:** \$42,000 of \$155,000 (27%), applied to data remediation workstream and vendor supplementation.

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### Budget Summary

| Workstream                          | Approved (\$)    | Actual (\$)      | Variance (\$)  |
|-------------------------------------|------------------|------------------|----------------|
| Cloud Infrastructure (Azure)        | 480,000          | 461,000          | +19,000        |
| Vendor - Platform & Implementation  | 1,100,000        | 1,088,000        | +12,000        |
| Data Engineering (Internal)         | 520,000          | 534,000          | -14,000        |
| BI & Reporting Development          | 310,000          | 298,000          | +12,000        |
| Data Governance & Change Management | 220,000          | 215,000          | +5,000         |
| Training & Adoption                 | 115,000          | 108,000          | +7,000         |
| Program Management                  | 200,000          | 186,000          | +14,000        |
| Contingency                         | 155,000          | 155,000          | 0              |
| <b>Total</b>                        | <b>3,100,000</b> | <b>3,045,000</b> | <b>+55,000</b> |

**Final variance: 1.8% under budget.**

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### Stakeholder Management Highlights

**Finance & Risk Teams (Primary Business Owners):** The most complex stakeholder relationship in the program. Finance and Risk had conflicting definitions for several key metrics (e.g., "Net Interest Margin" was calculated differently by each team). I facilitated a structured data governance workshop in Month 3 that brought both teams to an agreed canonical definition - documented in the data dictionary before any pipeline was built. This prevented rework and established trust early.

**FINTRAC & Regulatory Reporting Team:** Required careful management due to the regulatory sensitivity of their data outputs. I established a dedicated sub-working group with the Compliance Director as co-chair, with monthly milestone check-ins separate from the main working group cadence. Every regulatory pipeline was validated by a Compliance SME before UAT was declared complete.

**Vendor PM & Technical Team:** The vendor relationship was the highest-effort external stakeholder engagement on the program. Weekly joint delivery syncs, a shared risk log, and a clear escalation path to the vendor's account executive meant issues were resolved at the working level without needing Steering escalation in most cases. The one exception, a resourcing shortfall in Month 7, was resolved within 10 days through direct executive-level escalation on both sides.

**Business Users (200+ across 6 departments):** Adoption was the metric I most focused on throughout the program. I partnered with the Change Management Lead from Month 2, well before go-live, to design a super-user network, role-based training tracks, and a feedback loop that fed directly into BI development priorities. At the 90-day post-launch mark, active platform usage was at 84% of targeted users, exceeding the 75% target.

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## Program Outcomes

| Success Criterion                              | Target                | Achieved                        |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------|
| Delivery timeline                              | 18 months             | ✓ 18 months                     |
| Budget variance                                | Within 5%             | ✓ 1.8% under                    |
| Manual regulatory reporting effort reduction   | ≥ 70%                 | ✓ 78% reduction                 |
| Business user adoption (90 days post-launch)   | ≥ 75%                 | ✓ 84%                           |
| Data quality threshold (certified datasets)    | ≥ 98%                 | ✓ 99.1%                         |
| Legacy environments decommissioned             | 3                     | ✓ 3                             |
| Time-to-insight for executive reporting        | < 1 business day      | ✓ Same-day (automated)          |
| UAT defect rate at go-live                     | < 2% critical defects | ✓ 0 critical defects at go-live |
| Post-launch audit finding                      | 0                     | ✓ 0                             |
| Stakeholder satisfaction (post-program survey) | ≥ 4.0 / 5.0           | ✓ 4.4 / 5.0                     |

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## Lessons Learned

### What worked well:

- Starting data governance and change management in Phase 0, not Phase 3. Both disciplines need runway; retrofitting them late is the most common failure mode in data platform programs.
- The hybrid Agile/Waterfall model suited this program well. Infrastructure and vendor contracting needed milestone governance; pipeline development needed sprint agility. Forcing one model on both would have created friction.
- The canonical metric definition workshop in Month 3 prevented months of downstream rework. Investing early in getting stakeholders to agree on definitions pays back many times over.

**What I would do differently:**

- The data profiling exercise in Phase 0 should have been scoped more aggressively. We found more quality issues than anticipated when pipelines went into development. A heavier upfront investment in profiling would have produced a more accurate Phase 1 schedule.
  - The legacy decommission dependency was identified late. It should have been a named dependency in the charter, with an owner and a formal parallel run plan from day one.
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**PM Reflections**

This program reinforced something I believe strongly: the technical complexity of a data platform program is rarely the hardest part. The hardest part is getting fourteen stakeholders across Finance, Risk, Compliance, and Operations to agree on what a number means - and then holding that agreement for 18 months while the platform is built around it.

The governance framework, the data dictionary, and the canonical metric definitions. These were not documentation exercises. They were the foundation that made every downstream deliverable possible. Getting those right early is what allowed us to finish on time, under budget, and with a platform that people actually trust and use.

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